

Introduction: Methodological, Historical and Conceptual Starting Points

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Since the turn of the millennium, phenomenology has become one of the major approaches in contemporary philosophy of the mind and cognition. Phenomenological results and innovations have influenced not only theories of perception and cognition but also our views on social emotions and human coexistence. Consequently, contemporary phenomenology is well-known for its contributions to the philosophy of selfhood and pre-conceptual perception, for its explications of empathy, shame and guilt and for its emphasis on the facticity and plurality of human life. Phenomenological analyses have broadened our view of the interface between the mental and the physical, and they have contributed to our understanding of the classic division between the animal and the human as well as that between nature and culture. These insights have had considerable effects on present-day theorization of subjectivity and intersubjectivity and on the related discourses on personal and social identities, from philosophical anthropology to theories of gender and ethnicity.

In this development, phenomenology has entered into close exchanges with the empirical studies of the human psyche and human signification, most prominently with experimental psychology, neuroscience, cognitive science, psychiatry, psychoanalysis, anthropology, and social theory.¹ Consequently there is a growing interest to integrate phenomenological investigations with the empirical sciences. Moreover, the novel interdisciplinary attitude is not evident merely in inquiries into the human psyche or mind. Parallel developments manifest themselves in contemporary discussions of a number of other

¹ See, for example, Petitot et al. 1999, and the recent discussions in the journal *Phenomenology and Cognitive Science*.

topics, such as the topics of action, embodiment, nature, language, and gender.² Consequently the conceptual innovations of phenomenology now often combine with and contribute to a variety of empiricist and naturalistic theoretical enterprises.

Contemporary naturalism, however, is not a single philosophical position. It includes a variety of different approaches to mental and cultural phenomena, ranging from extreme physicalist and eliminativist approaches to non-reductive post-pragmatic and neo-Aristotelian theories. These approaches differ significantly in their accounts of human experience and its relation to the material world. However, they all share one characteristic that may prove problematic in the attempt to naturalize phenomenology or to combine phenomenology with the positive sciences: they take for granted the senses of nature and the world, which are operative in the theoretical discourses of the natural world and the human being, and do not offer tools that would enable us to problematize these senses radically enough for constitutive inquiries that concern their institution and reinstitution. According to the classic phenomenological argument, the idea of science as a theoretical practice implies the task of examining the senses of the world and nature operative in all naturalization projects. We do not need to assume an all-encompassing viewpoint external to human capacities in order to execute such inquiries but can rely on our human capacities of critique, discrimination, and reflection.

This book is an attempt to answer these shortcomings. It argues for the indispensability of the transcendental standpoint for phenomenology and philosophical reasoning in general. The concept of the transcendental, however, is not understood here as referring to a pre-given domain of experience, sense, or inquiry. Instead, it denotes a general motive of philosophical reflection that does not take for granted the everyday attitude or the results of the special sciences but asks for their foundation in our basic experience of the

² See, e.g., Zahavi (ed.) 2012.

world. To put it in the language of modern philosophy, transcendental inquiries concern those *conditions of possibility* which allow us to constitute the world as true, valid and objective, and ourselves as beings in this world. Transcendental knowledge, in contrast to a common misconception, is not something that transcends our lives and our understanding; instead, it is an investigation into the senses operative in our experiences.

In his groundbreaking work *Ideas: General Introduction to Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy* (1913), Edmund Husserl argued for the necessity of establishing the phenomenological method on a universal suspension of all conviction about the reality of nature and the world, implicated in our theoretical and practical, scientific and everyday beliefs and cognitions.³ The aim, he explained, was not to doubt or negate the world nor to establish another foundation for human knowledge but to interrupt our natural belief in the presence and reality of the world for the single purpose of clarifying transcendently the conditions and the origin of this belief and everything that depends on it. Husserl wrote:

If I do this, as I am fully free to do, I do not then deny this ‘world,’ as though I were a sophist, I do *not doubt that it is there* as though I were a skeptic; but I use the ‘phenomenological’ epoché which *completely bars me from using any judgment that concerns spatio-temporal existence* (...) The whole world as placed within the nature-setting and presented in experience as real, taken completely ‘free from all theory,’ just as it is in reality experienced, and made clearly manifest in and through the linkings of our experience, has now no validity for us, it must be set in brackets, untested indeed but also uncontested. Similarly all theories and sciences, positivistic or otherwise, which relate to the world, however good they may be, succumb to the

³ Originally *Ideen zu einer reinen Phänomenologie und phänomenologischen Philosophie*.

same fate. (Hua 3, 56–57/100)

The epoché makes possible the crucial step that Husserl called ‘the phenomenological reduction’ and that consists of the thematization of the correlation between our conscious state and the world. Together these two steps allow us to interrupt our natural attention to the world and focus our studies on our sense-constitutive activities and passivities. Thus the main function of the reduction is to enable the explication of the constitutive operations that are responsible for the sense and comprehensibility of the world.

Husserl’s radical philosophical aspiration does not just demarcate phenomenology from those theoretical approaches that call themselves “naturalistic.” The very same radicalism separates Husserlian phenomenology also from those constructivist approaches that study the ideas of nature, the natural world, and human nature by inserting them in social, historical, or social-historical circumstances. The shortcomings of all such approaches, Husserl explains, are fundamentally similar. As they trace the sense of nature or the natural back to historical and social processes, they necessarily presuppose the world as a framework or horizon in which the relevant circumstances prevail and events proceed.⁴ The fundamental presupposition of the world is left intact even if the senses of nature and the natural world are investigated as social or historical accomplishments since these accomplishments are still conceptualized as *wordly* events or processes. In other words, on Husserl’s analysis, the social and historical constructivist approaches are not radical enough for philosophical purposes.⁵

⁴ This argument is spelled out in a compact way in the so-called *Logos*-essay, “Philosophy as rigorous science” (originally *Philosophie als strenge Wissenschaft* (1911).

⁵ Similar argument has been voiced by philosophers working in the analytical tradition of modern philosophy, for example, by Hilary Putnam. In his article, “Why reason cannot be

From a phenomenological standpoint, no factual construction, be it naturalistic or historicist, can settle philosophical questioning. Philosophy, in this view, charts possibilities, not realities.⁶ It is not a logical construction but establishes itself as a transcendental inquiry into the conditions of possibility of our experience of the world and everything within it (including logic).

The volume at hand is motivated by the insight that the novel interdisciplinary situation in which phenomenology conducts fruitful exchanges with several empirical sciences demands that we reconsider thoroughly the fundamental methodological questions concerning the transcendental character of phenomenological inquiries. *Phenomenology and the Transcendental* brings together original articles that together clarify the transcendental aspects of phenomenology and outline new transcendental versions of phenomenology in distinction from the naturalistic, vitalist, and post-structuralist approaches that dominate philosophy at the moment.⁷ The volume thus contributes to the development of contemporary phenomenology in two related ways: It deepens the topical debates by offering fresh

naturalized” (1983), Putnam distinguished between two main senses of “naturalism,” reductive physicalistic, on the one hand, motivated by the success of the modern natural sciences, and cultural relativism, on the other hand, motivated by the findings of contemporary anthropology. Paradoxically these two forms of naturalism tend toward opposite attitudes in epistemology and metaphysics, one toward absolutism and monism and the other toward relativism and pluralism. What is common to both of them, according to Putnam, is that they give up making sense of normativity in its genuine sense, the sense that is imperative to logic, epistemology, and ethics.

For phenomenology of normativity, see Crowell 2013. For naturalist attempts to account for normativity, see, e.g., De Caro and Macarthur 2010 and Milkowski and Talmont-Kaminski 2010. For how some philosophers turn to transcendental philosophy, although not to phenomenology, in response to different kinds of shortcomings of the naturalist point of view, see Smith and Sullivan 2011.

⁶ In the essay “Philosophy and sociology” (1960), Merleau-Ponty formulates this idea as follows: “History, Husserl used to say (...) cannot judge an idea; and when it does, this ‘evaluating’ (*wertende*) history borrows surreptitiously from the ‘ideal sphere’ the necessary connections which it pretends to bring forth from the facts.” (Merleau-Ponty 1960, 129/103).

⁷ By contemporary “vitalist approaches” we mean ontological and epistemological approaches that are based on or motivated by Spinozist, Nietzschean or Bergsonian metaphysics of forces and objects, such as Deleuze’s transcendental empiricism or contemporary traits of “speculative materialism”.

methodological and metaphilosophical insights. It also extends the established topical range by arguing that phenomenology is not tied to any specific topics, whether in perception and cognition, in empathy and social emotions, or in our mental lives as wholes. Accordingly phenomenology defines a methodology that can be applied in multiple topical areas. This way, phenomenology broadens significantly the scope of classic transcendental philosophy towards new domains of experience, including the temporal development of personhood, mortality and generativity, animality, and materiality.

1. On the Classic Concept of the Transcendental

Although the idea of transcendental philosophy is associated with philosophical ideas that are characteristically modern, the concept of the transcendental dates back to medieval thought. The notions of *transcendentia* and later *transcendentalia* were first used during the 13th century to denote those properties that characterize being in all of its instances and thus “transcend” all individual categories. This idea had its background in the Aristotelian doctrine of “being” (*to on*) and “one” (*to hen*) as the universal characteristics of all being – real or ideal, sensed or intuited – which are needed for any sense of “meaning” or “reality” to come about.

The medieval authors, and particularly St. Thomas Aquinas, followed Aristotle in emphasizing the fundamental role of the concepts of *res* and *unum*, being and unity, as the primary transcendentals. However, they also broadened the scope of transcendental attributes to include the relationality of beings to each other and to the intellect. According to Thomas,

every being is also defined by its difference from all other beings – i.e., as something (*aliquid*) – as well as by its “trueness” (*verum*) and “goodness” (*bonum*).

This broadened notion of the transcendental served as the basic point of departure for the modern reformulation of transcendental philosophy in the works of Immanuel Kant. According to the classic definition provided by Kant’s *Critique of Pure Reason*, the expression “transcendental” is to refer to “all cognition which is occupied not so much with objects as with the mode of our cognition of objects in so far as this mode of cognition is to be possible *a priori*” (Kant CPR A11-12/B25).

Thus the domain of transcendental reflection was to be relocated in experience rather than the experienced reality, and, accordingly, transcendental philosophy was supposed to constitute a system of such knowledge with a clear demarcation between necessary and contingent aspects of human cognition. While Kant acknowledged that the history of the notion of transcendental dated back already to “the ancients,” he nevertheless maintained that the medieval doctrine of the *transcendentalia* could only amount to tautological propositions of mutually convertible definitions (CPR B113). Instead of mere tautological or “analytic” definitions, the new domain of the transcendental was to consist of *synthetic a priori* judgments that genuinely reveal something novel about the structures of cognition and thus add to our knowledge.

Kant characterized his method of discovering the transcendentals by the term “deduction.” This term that was adopted from the legal context of the time referred basically to the idea of justification that was at the heart of Kant’s philosophical method. While the *a priori* principles of cognition serve as the basis for all of our knowledge, they are not themselves beyond all proof: they, too, require justification in order to be operative (CPR A148 / B188). We cannot assume the amount of categories, their types or any other *a priori*

principles beforehand, nor can we simply apply them to reality. Their legitimacy must be demonstrated in a way which excludes all other ideas, concepts or principles as possible explanations of the phenomena. Despite the radical character of his approach, Kant nevertheless took it for granted that we can, and must, derive the categories from logic. He argues that because logic had not progressed since Aristotle, it was “a closed and complete body of doctrine” and could thus serve as the model for categories (CPR Bviii).

The core of Kant’s method of transcendental deduction was based on his argument for the unity of conscious life. Not only do we judge the appearing things as being of certain qualities and quantities, but our experiencing is always accompanied by certain “mineness.” Kant turned back to Descartes and emphasized the representation “I think” (*cogito*) as something which accompanies all experiencing. He termed this representation as “pure apperception” or “original apperception” – literally, the surplus of perception – and he argued that it also constituted the foundation of all self-consciousness *per se*: “I also call its unity the *transcendental unity of self-consciousness* in order to designate the possibility of a priori cognition from it” (CPR B132).

Although Kant was favorable to the Cartesian idea of *cogito* he followed Hume in rejecting Descartes’ solution according to which the transcendental self can be characterized and understood in terms of *res cogitans*, a thinking thing or substance. Instead of a mental entity, the necessary self of all experiencing was to be understood as a non-intuitable pole of experience that lacks “any quality whatsoever” (CPR A355). Thus in its apperceived form, Kant argued, the transcendental ego “contains nothing manifold” (CPR B135) – as human beings, we all are instantiations of the same transcendental ego.

These arguments constitute the kernel of Kant’s doctrine of *transcendental idealism*. Thus in its Kantian sense, idealism does not depend on the notion of the subject as the creator

or producer of the world but instead asserts and argues for the indispensable role of self-consciousness in the constitution of a meaningful experience of transcendence, that is, of the world and its objects.

Kant's transcendental idealism was notoriously haunted by the ambiguous surplus element of worldly transcendence, that is, the "things themselves," that helped to guarantee the distinction between appearance and reality. Although Kant's appeal to "things in themselves" allows several different interpretations and although this idea can be supported by multiple arguments, its perplexing and ambiguous character was one of the main reasons that lead the German idealists, Fichte and Hegel, to refute Kant's doctrine of transcendental idealism in favor of "absolute idealism," which emphasized the ultimate unity of thinking and being and traced the development of self-consciousness through (historical) time.

Despite this critical reaction, transcendental philosophy was not completely abandoned by the 19th century philosophers. It was further developed by a wide variety of thinkers often referred to as "neo-Kantians," who emphasized the need to turn back to study and work on the Kantian problematics of the possibility of knowledge. Critical epistemology, not metaphysics or ontology, was to be located at the heart of philosophical reflection. In the works of Hermann Cohen, Paul Natorp, and Ernst Cassirer, however, the classical Kantian problematics of cognition was set free from its strictly logical aspects that concerned the general conditions of possible knowledge. The Kantian task of executing transcendental inquiries into such conditions merged with the interest to accommodate the structures of human cognition with the rapid development of the modern natural sciences as well as with the multiplicity of human cultures and their symbolic forms. Here, the debate concerning the transcendental approach and its proper character became the decisive point for the autonomy of philosophical knowledge, its separation from the mere idea of a "world-view" (*Weltanschauung*), but also for the very unity of the scientific enterprise in general: What is

the relation between the natural-scientific and the human-scientific knowledge? Do they share a common foundation in the cognitive structures of the human subject?

The stimulating role of neo-Kantianism in regard to the emergence of the phenomenological movement can hardly be exaggerated. Both Husserl and Heidegger were deeply influenced by the two main strands of the neo-Kantian movement: the Marburg school of Cohen, Natorp, and Cassirer, as well as the Baden school of Wilhelm Windelband and Heinrich Rickert. The anti-metaphysical and anti-speculative connotations of phenomenology were in line with the epistemological interest of the neo-Kantians. The explicitly Kantian nomenclature of Husserl – ego, subject, and self-consciousness – as well as the emphasis on “factual life” of the early Heidegger both alluded to the neo-Kantian problematic.⁸

However, as the historical development of the phenomenological movement shows, the relation between the idea of phenomenological inquiries, on the one hand, and the idea of transcendental inquiries, on the other hand, is far from being clear. Husserl’s late problematic of the lifeworld, Heidegger’s turn to the history of being, Merleau-Ponty’s discourse on the element of the flesh as well as Sartre’s interest in the Hegelian problematic of recognition can all be interpreted as critical confrontations with the basic theses of the Kantian tradition: the primacy of consciousness over the world, of epistemology over ontology, of theory over praxis, of mind over body, and of cognition over affection. Still, giving up completely on making the distinction between transcendental and empirical inquiries would mean that we renounce many of the central themes and arguments of classical phenomenologists, and this risks that we miss altogether what they conceived of as the *differentia specifica* of philosophical reflection as such.

⁸ In regard to the topic of facticity, Heidegger was influenced especially by Dilthey’s treatises on the historicity of human life. See Bambach 1995. Cf. Also Steven Crowell’s article in this collection.

2. Husserl and the Possibility of Transcendental Phenomenology

Husserl's first seminal work *Logical Investigations*, the “breakthrough of phenomenology”, was published in two volumes in 1900 and 1901. Its relation to Kantian transcendental philosophy was highly ambiguous. On the one hand, Husserl's rejection of contemporary psychologism seemed to refer to the need for a strict transcendental investigation. The central role of the notion of “intuition” (*Anschauung*) rang the bells of any Kantian, and in the *Prolegomena* Husserl explicitly argued that the role of pure logic is to give us conditions of the possibility of theory in general. On the other hand, Husserl explicitly rejected the Kantian doctrine of the pure ego that had been promoted by Natorp; moreover, his famous exposition on the “categorical intuition” was in clear opposition to the Kantian division between sensibility and understanding. What is certain, however, is that the unclarities relating to the transcendental problematic – its foundation, method and scope – influenced the development of Husserl's thought all the way to his late works.

In Husserl-scholarship, it has become usual to speak of the so-called “transcendental turn” in Husserl's thinking, a development that took place between the first edition of the *Logical Investigations* and the first volume of *Ideas* (1913). This development was marked by the explication of the method of the transcendental-phenomenological reduction and by the discovery of the transcendental ego.⁹ A new Kantian motive emerged in Husserl's philosophy

⁹ Whether the change in Husserl's thinking should be viewed as a turn away from his earlier work or rather as an expansion of it is intensively debated in the secondary literature. The readings that emphasize the transcendental character of his reflections avoid the fruitless debate whether his philosophy is realistic or idealistic. Some scholars argue that already Husserl's *Logical Investigations* can be read as a transcendental philosophical work. Such an interpretation is favored especially among those who emphasize the continuity of the

and opened a new set of research tasks. The Kantian and Cartesian terms ‘transcendental ego,’ ‘self,’ and ‘subject’ received radical redefinitions in the novel “critique of reason” that Husserl proposed in a Kantian line.¹⁰ The transcendental ego was not to be arrived at via speculation or transcendental deduction but by holding fast to the principle of intuition. Thus whatever structures or features we may label as transcendental, they must be straightforwardly *given* in experience. For this reason, Husserl was able to consider Descartes as the true originator of the transcendental motive of modern philosophy:

I should like to note the following right away: the expression “transcendental philosophy” has been much used since Kant, even as a general title for universal philosophies whose concepts are oriented toward those of the Kantian type. I myself use the word “transcendental” in the broadest sense for the original motif, discussed in detail above, which through Descartes confers meaning upon all modern philosophies, the motif which, in all of them, seeks to come to itself, so to speak – seeks to attain

development of Husserl’s views (cf. Cobb-Stevens, 2003). For example, Sokolowski (2000, 211) holds that the first truly phenomenological work is Husserl’s *Logical Investigations* 1900-1901, and by “truly phenomenological” he refers to the philosophical reflection in the transcendental as opposed to all naturalistic reflections. The idea seems to be that already in the *Logical Investigations*, prior to the explication and development of the method of reduction, Husserl performs a reduction via the “ontological way,” i.e., he starts with the sciences and turns into a transcendental reflection on their conditions of possibility. According to Sokolowski Husserl gave the name “reduction” to mark the distinction between phenomenology and psychology that was already brewing in the *Logical Investigations* (Sokolowski 2008, 171-2). Along these lines, also John Drummond has argued that Husserl’s turn to transcendental phenomenology is not a departure from the approach of the *Logical Investigations* but is an extension of this approach (Drummond 2002). Husserl himself has characterized his own analyses in the *Philosophy of Arithmetic* as phenomenological-constitutional in their attempt at making “‘categorical objectivities’ [...] understandable on the basis of the ‘constituting’ intentional activities” (Hua 17 §27a). This suggests that Husserl’s project could be understood, at least retrospectively, to be in some sense transcendental already in the 1890s.

¹⁰ HuaDok 3/5, 14. Cf. Mohanty 1996. In the second edition of the *Logical Investigation* published in 1913, contrary to his earlier position, Husserl claimed to have discovered the domain of the pure ego while distancing himself from the “corrupt forms of ego-metaphysic” (Hua 19/1, 374).

the genuine and pure form of its task and its systematic development. (Hua 6, 100/97)¹¹

Transcendental phenomenology, accordingly, was to found itself as a *descriptive* science – although its scope was not to be restricted in the domain of descriptive statements or theoretical reason. Especially in his later works on the crisis of the European sciences, Husserl emphasized the role of transcendental thought in the unification – or reunification – of the domains of theory and praxis, and the rearticulation of philosophical self-responsibility on the basis of their union.

Husserl's relation to the very content of transcendental philosophy can be viewed as a radicalization, a rearticulation, and a distention of the Kantian concept of the transcendental. It was a radicalization insofar as Husserl extended the transcendental critique also to logic that Kant had taken for granted. It was a rearticulation insofar as Husserl, by emphasizing the idea of givenness rather than deduction, located the domain of transcendental within the individual ego, thus making the transcendental ego inextricably *personal* and *singular*. But it was also a distention as Husserl significantly broadened the scope of transcendental investigation to include the temporal development of the ego, its bodily existence and intersubjective relations. Moreover, instead of focusing solely on the inner life of the subject, the scope of the transcendental was to be extended to its historical, social and geographical conditions in the lifeworld. Even the topics of culture and communal life were to be framed

¹¹ See also Husserl's emphasis on the Cartesian dimension of the transcendental problematic in the *Crisis*: "What the modern period calls the theory of the understanding or of reason — in the pregnant sense "critique of reason," transcendental problematic — has the roots of its meaning in the Cartesian Meditations. The ancient world was not acquainted with this sort of thing, since the Cartesian *epoché* and its ego were unknown. Thus, in truth, there begins with Descartes a completely new manner of philosophizing which seeks its ultimate foundations in the subjective" (Hua 6, 83/81).

as transcendental. Let us shortly focus on the character of the transcendental ego, its singularity and its facticity.

The primary justification for Husserl's use of the notion of "transcendental" was based on the "Cartesian" discovery according to which the mode of being characteristic of consciousness differs essentially from that of worldly beings. It is possible to imagine a consciousness without a world, but not a world without an ego to which it is given: hence, consciousness is the transcendental condition of all transcendence, the world. However, we do not infer this condition from individual experiences but we are constantly living it through, which makes the transcendental ego something which Kant never saw it to be: an inextricably singular being. But if the transcendental ego is singular then it means that the domain of transcendentality is really nothing separate from the concrete, worldly person; rather, the transcendental and the empirical refer to two different *aspects* within the conscious life of the individual.

This insight becomes clear as we focus on the topic of embodiment. On the one hand, it is quite obvious that as empirical beings in the world, we are similar to other concrete things, such as trees and tables – we have "bodies" or *Körper* as Husserl would have put it. On the other hand, it is equally clear that our conscious bodily existence differs radically from the bodily existence of material objects; we are not mere physical things but "living bodies" (*Leibe*) that are able to see, hear and touch things and to discover the limits of our body through self-affection.¹² As Husserl insists, it is impossible to imagine perception without a living bodily existence, which makes bodily existence a transcendental condition. But this idea does not do away with our empirical being in the world – the empirical and the

¹² On the topic of the living body, See Sara Heinämaa's, Hanne Jacobs' and Joona Taipale's articles in this collection.

transcendental are thus two sides of the same coin. We are, as Husserl put it in his later works, defined by this complex “paradox of subjectivity.”¹³

The same goes for our relations to other experiencing subjects. The others are there in my field of experience as fellow human beings – parents, siblings, friends and strangers – with whom I can interact and communicate in multiple ways. However, I am also linked with others simply by my capacity of grasping the world: the very sense of the world as an infinite and exhaustible whole implies the infinity of possible observers with perspectives and horizons that transcend my individual perceptions. In other words, the objectivity of the world necessitates, as its condition, the multiplicity of different horizons of experiencing. As Husserl put it in his *Cartesian Meditations*, it is actually the “transcendental we” that deserves to be called the genuine subject of the world, or, what he elsewhere termed as the “concrete absolute.” Thus the phenomenon of intersubjectivity, too, bears transcendental significance.¹⁴

There are, of course, points in which Husserl’s definition of the transcendental resembled significantly that of Kant’s. For one, Husserl credited Kant for his unique attempt of describing the field of sensuous intuition not only as a raw data-like givenness but as a *productive activity*, which founds the predicative forms of experience. In other words, Kant demonstrated that receptivity is not merely a subject matter of psychology but also a topic for transcendental investigations. However, since Kant conceived of the transcendental ego to be atemporal and unchanging, he failed – and this from a Husserlian perspective – to investigate into the essential laws and elementary facts of this productive activity (Hua 11, 119). Kant did not bring together the associative synthesis with the temporal structure of transcendental

¹³ Hua 6, 182/178. See also Carr 1999.

¹⁴ Cf. Timo Miettinen’s article in this collection.

consciousness: his account was unable to question how individual associations provide the transcendental life with its peculiar shape.¹⁵

This lack motivated Husserl to develop his unique theory of *transcendental person*. I do not merely “live through” individual acts, but these acts have the tendency of creating lasting tendencies, patterns and intentions, which become part of my personal history. These tendencies may manifest themselves, for instance, in the form of lasting “convictions” (*Überzeugungen*), “decisions” (*Entscheidungen*), or “resolutions of the will” (*Willenentschlüsse*) (e.g. Hua 39, 47). As such, such convictions endow my transcendental ego with its essential uniqueness, its personal history and character. This is why Husserl stresses that the notions of habitus and style should not be taken in their everyday sense of custom and routine nor should they be equated with memory or recollection.¹⁶ Instead, they should be understood as transcendental features that belong primordially to the sphere of pure ego (Hua 4, 111).

3. Husserl’s Legacy

The development of phenomenology after Husserl has been significantly guided by the question of the possibility of the transcendental standpoint. While it is evident that Heidegger, already in his earliest lectures, framed his conceptual approach in clear contrast to the

¹⁵ See e.g. Kant’s *Critique*: “Actual experience, which is constituted by apprehension, association (reproduction), and finally recognition of appearances, contains in recognition, the last and highest of these *merely empirical elements of experience*, certain concepts which render possible the formal unity of experience, and therewith all objective validity (truth) of empirical knowledge.” (CPR A124–125).

¹⁶ Here Husserlian phenomenology parallels interestingly with William James’ classic pragmatist theory of habits.

Cartesian-Kantian vocabulary of ego, subject and consciousness, it is nevertheless clear that the ideas of “factual life” and *Dasein* did not entail a breakaway from the transcendental problematic. As emphasized in the introduction to the *Being and Time*, an investigation into the fundamental structures of *Dasein* as transcendence – as a being that constantly exceeds itself both temporally and to the world – constitutes essentially a “transcendental knowledge.” The analyses of worldliness and practical being at-hand as well as the threefold division between “disposedness” (*Befindlichkeit*), “understanding” (*Verstehen*), and “discourse” (*Rede*) can easily be located within a transcendental framework. The same cannot be as easily said of Heidegger’s later thinking, which can be interpreted, at least partially, as a resolute attempt of distancing oneself from the subjectivist outlook of modern transcendental philosophy towards a new philosophy that articulates the fundamental receptivity of the human being (for whom “there is being,” *es gibt Sein*).

Existential phenomenologists, most prominently Jean-Paul Sartre and Maurice Merleau-Ponty, developed further Husserl’s and Heidegger’s transcendental inquiries. They combined phenomenology effectively with methods, concepts, and insights stemming from several intellectual movements, from French Cartesianism and vitalism (Malebranche, Maine de Biran, and Bergson), from structuralist anthropology and linguistics (Saussure and Lévi-Strauss), from the 20th century interpretations of Hegel (Kojève and Hyppolite), and from the critiques that Kierkegaard and Nietzsche directed against Hegel’s universalism and finalism. Despite the synthetic character of their discourses, the French existentialists pursued transcendental investigations that concerned the conditions of perception and communication, the limits of selfhood and personhood and the intentional operations that egoic and personal subjects can perform.

Merleau-Ponty’s analyses of embodiment and expressivity in *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) aimed at articulating the conditions of objective perception and disclosing

the dynamic structures of preconceptual and affective consciousness.¹⁷ His later ontology of flesh, as outlined in *The Visible and the Invisible* (1964)¹⁸ and related manuscripts and lectures, is today commonly associated with Bergson's vitalism, Schelling's or Spinoza's monism, and Whitehead's philosophy of nature, but despite such classically metaphysical resonances, Merleau-Ponty still formulates his philosophical aims in terms of the reductive method of Husserlian phenomenology: "I will finally be able to take a position in ontology (...) and specify its theses exactly, only after the series of reductions (...) which are all in the first one, but also are truly accomplished only in the last one" (1964, 233/179; cf. 1964, 207–208/156–157, 219/165–166).¹⁹

Following Eugen Fink's sixth Cartesian Meditation, Merleau-Ponty argued that the radical character of phenomenology remains a promise unless phenomenology incorporates an account of its own motivations and its reflective and conceptual-linguistic operations. What is needed is a "phenomenology of phenomenology" and this, Merleau-Ponty contended, can and must be grounded in a new intensified or deepened type of reflection, that is a "hyper-reflexion" (*sur-réflexion*), that is conscious of its living roots in prereflective experience and of the changes that it introduces in experience (Merleau-Ponty 1964, 61/38; cf. [1945] 1993, 75–76/61–63). As reckoned already in *Phenomenology*, this requires that phenomenology realizes the temporal character of its own analyses of sense constitution and the *eide* of experiencing and proceeds to a genetic stage:

Until some means has been discovered whereby we can link the origin and the essence or meaning of the [experience]; until some definition is found for a concrete essence, a structure of [experience] which shall express both its generality and its

¹⁷ Originally *Phénoménologie de la perception*.

¹⁸ Originally *Le visible et l'invisible*.

¹⁹ Cf. Fink [1988] 1995, 71–76; Bruzina 2004, 151–152.

particularity, until phenomenology becomes genetic phenomenology, unhelpful reversions to causal thought and naturalism will remain justified. (Merleau-Ponty [1945] 1993, 146–147/126)²⁰

Expanding on this line of thought, the volume at hand takes seriously the dynamic character of phenomenology.²¹ The authors of this work understand the concept of the transcendental primarily in terms of a movement or a motive that does not simply leave behind the empirical reality but asks for its conditions of possibility in the experiencing subject, its correlates, and its manifold intentional layers. The task of transcendental reflection is to make explicit how the world, its objectivity and validity, depends on the constitutive functions of subjectivity and intersubjectivity. Correlatively, it must also ask to what extent these functions themselves are embedded in different worldly structures.

The volume at hand consists of four parts. Part I *Transcendental Phenomenology* includes principled discussions on the nature of transcendental phenomenology, its main variations and its relation to the tradition of transcendental philosophy. It outlines the historical development which starts with Kant and continues to present day debates about the proper tasks and methods of phenomenological philosophy. Finally, part I presents new interpretations of transcendental phenomenology and thus it demonstrates how contemporary phenomenologists work to continue and develop transcendental inquiries without falling back on any form of metaphysical foundationalism.

²⁰ Cf. Merleau-Ponty 1964, 70–71/46–47; Fink [1988] 1995, 77–84.

²¹ Cf. Laszlo Tengelyi's chapter in this volume.

The volume opens with the article “Transcendental Life,” in which Steven Crowell discusses Husserl and Heidegger as paradigms of transcendental thinking. The chapter argues for the indispensability of the transcendental phenomenological point of view when approaching normativity. Thus it gives a detailed answer to why the naturalist approaches cannot adequately address the questions of logic, epistemology, aesthetics, and ethics. In his chapter, “Categories of Experience and the Transcendental,” Laszlo Tengelyi clarifies the way in which Husserl’s notion of the transcendental relates to Kant’s notion. Most importantly, in contrast to Kant’s transcendental deduction of categories that proceeds on a priori grounds, the phenomenologist’s transcendental argument is based on the contingent fact that the world exists. Tengelyi locates the main difference between Kant’s and the phenomenologist’s approaches to their respective notion of necessity, which in phenomenology is not a priori necessity, but *factual necessity* that arises from experience. His chapter also importantly suggests that Husserl’s notion of the transcendental should be understood in the framework of Kant’s Third Critique rather than the First. While the two previous chapters study and discuss the nature of transcendental phenomenology, Bernhard Obsieger’s article, “The Transcendental Nature of Experience,” dives into the phenomenological way of philosophizing and actually carries out a transcendental phenomenological analysis of temporality and intersubjectivity.

Part II, *Subjectivity and Intersubjectivity*, further clarifies the structures of transcendental subjectivity and intersubjectivity and the Husserlian concepts of activity and passivity. The essays in this part demonstrate that transcendental phenomenology is not mere epistemology but also analyzes dependencies that are relevant to social philosophy, political philosophy, and ethics. The constituting self, as disclosed in the essays, is not an empty pole, a formal principle or solitary agent, but has a temporal character, a bodily dimension, and communal linkages. By emphasizing the temporal character of constitution, this part also

brings to the view the constitutive function of passivity. It argues that, rather than an immutable and amorphous mass from which conscious acts lade or bail, passivity can and must be conceived in dynamic terms as the developing source and result of activity. The first chapter in the second section takes us first into the conception of the human being in the naturalistic attitude, then in the personalistic attitude, and eventually in the transcendental attitude. In “Transcendental Subjectivity and the Human Being,” Hanne Jacobs thematizes the basic difference between two main attitudes that we can take to human beings: the naturalistic attitude of the natural sciences that theorize human beings as physicalistic systems or psycho-physical wholes, and the personalistic attitude in which the human being is apprehended as a communicating and expressive subject of actions and passions. Jacobs emphasizes that the two realms of being delineated in these attitudes are not ontologically distinct, and she argues that the naturalistic attitude presupposes the personalistic pre-givenness of the human being as a communicating and expressive subject. On the basis of these explications, Jacobs then reconsiders the nature or character of transcendental subjectivity and its self-constitution as a human being. In “Husserl on the Factical and Historical Grounds of the Transcendental Subject,” Simo Pulkkinen argues that while passivity founds our actual attentive acts, these acts, on the other hand, come to form a “secondary passivity” by the processes of association and habituation. The accomplishment of an act does not vanish with the ceasing of the act but pertains and participates as a habitual formation in subsequent meaning constitution. Thus transcendental subjectivity is affected by its own historicity, and this makes it dynamic and embedded in the world and in the intersubjective community. Pulkkinen’s paper thus shows in detail how the embeddedness of an agent comes about.

In “The Animal and the Infant: From Embodiment and Empathy to Generativity,” Sara Heinämaa argues that the Husserl’s discourse of transcendental intersubjectivity

includes an important analysis that binds the full sense of the world to a specific form of intersubjectivity organized into generations and chains of generations. The figures of the infant and the animal are crucial to this analysis. By explicating Husserl's line of thought on this point and by developing it further, Heinämaa argues that language has a central role in the constitution of the crucial form of intersubjectivity that correlates with the full sense of the world. This helps us to distinguish between the constitutive functions on linguistic and nonlinguistic communities. In the article "Transcendental Social Ontology", Timo Miettinen discusses the significance of the transcendental approach for Husserl's theory of intersubjectivity. According to his reading, Husserl did not conceive communities merely as derivative phenomena of the individual ego; instead, his phenomenology of intersubjectivity was able to afford communities a transcendental status. The problem of sociality cannot thus be returned back to the idea of shared intentions or common mental states, but it entails a fundamental relation to *transcendence*, that is, to the constitution of a common world. Phenomenological social ontology, Miettinen concludes, must be approached from the idea of transcendental correlation, that is, the relation between constituting subjectivity and constituted accomplishments.

Part III *World, Object, Body* switches the focus and studies the concepts of the world and the body and the role of the object in transcendental phenomenology. In his contribution, "The Emergence and Transformation of Husserl's Concept of World," David Carr traces the development of the Husserl's conception of the world from its first appearance as the common sense view of the world to life-world that is prior to any scientific or practical attitudes. Carr argues that once the concept of world moves into a central position in Husserl's formulation of the phenomenological method, it undergoes a series of transformations that culminate in the concept of the lifeworld in the 1930s. As the last publication *The Crisis of European Sciences* shows, two related research tasks ensue from

these transformations: the task of establishing the ontology of the lifeworld and the task of inquiring into the transcendental grounds of this ontology. In the next chapter “Phenomenological Sources, Kantian Borders: An Outline of Transcendental Philosophy as Object-Guided Philosophy,” Sophie Loidolt discusses the transcendental attitude towards the world and argues for an object-guided transcendental phenomenology. Loidolt emphasizes the Kantian kernel of transcendental philosophy and points out that this kernel does not just include the idea of correlation but also implies that the possible objects of experience have necessary transcendental structures. Basing on this, Loidolt argues that, instead of being conceived and practiced as a philosophy of pure subjectivity, phenomenology can and must be developed as an inquiry into the very structures of objectivity. In “William James on Consciousness and the Brain: From Psycho-Physical Dualism to Transcendental Philosophy,” Richard Cobb-Stevens then explores the borderline between Husserlian phenomenology and William James’s pragmatism highlighting transcendental features in James’ thought. In particular, he argues that James’s conception of pure experience should be understood along the transcendental lines as explicated by Husserl, in which the dualisms between mind and body as well as appearance and reality are overcome. The same world is examined within the transcendental attitude that enables us to pay attention to the ways in which the world presents itself. Thus the phenomena thematized in phenomenology must be understood as manifestations of things themselves – a notion whose roots can be traced back to Antiquity. Joona Taipale’s chapter “The Bodily Feeling of Existence in Phenomenology and Psychoanalysis” continues with a detailed examination of the transcendental phenomenological account of the body, and compares and contrasts it to the notions of the body in Freudian psychoanalysis. Despite the fact that psychoanalysis remains a non-transcendental discipline, Taipale illustrates important connections between these two discourses on human embodiment. His contribution thus explores the borders of

transcendental phenomenology and demonstrates that “factual” necessity, as Tengelyi would put it, makes transcendental phenomenology continuous with certain empirical approaches.

Part IV *Beyond the Correlation* discusses recent criticisms that motivate the move beyond transcendental phenomenology and demonstrates that this move cannot mean a step back to pre-transcendental inquiries but must rather proceed forward. Rather than naturalizing phenomenology or inserting phenomenological inquiries into some positive ontology, this final part of the volume argues that transcendental philosophy can and must be developed by a radicalization of its questions. Thus traditional transcendental inquiries concerning the limits of human experience and knowledge are subordinated to questions which concern the roots of our present interest in the limitations or the unlimitedness of knowledge.

First in “What is a Transcendental Description?” Fredrik Westerlund discusses two principal objections that have been presented against phenomenology: subjectivism and essentialism. He argues that the former form of criticism can be countered but the latter cannot. Consequently, he holds, transcendental phenomenology should be conceived as the delineation of the general paradigms of meaning whose range and force lies in their de facto capacity to clarify individual cases of intending, and should not be assimilated with any pursuit for the essential features of experiencing. The question is whether such an enterprise still can or should be called “transcendental.” In his chapter, “Transcendental Idealism and Strong Correlationism: Meillassoux and the End of Heideggerian Finitude” Jussi Backman discusses Quentin Meillassoux’s recent interpretation and critique of Heidegger’s philosophical position. The chapter emphasizes the fact that, Meillassoux situates Heidegger in the post-Kantian tradition of transcendental idealism that he defines by the idea of correlation between being and thinking. Backman then argues that Meillassoux’s “speculative” attempt to overcome the Kantian philosophical framework in the name of absolute contingency should be understood as a further development of its ultimate

contemporary form, the Heideggerian philosophy of finitude. Niall Keane's chapter, "*Die Kehre spielt im Sachverhalt selbst* - Making Sense of the Twists and Turns in Heidegger's Thought" discusses the influential notion that there is a groundbreaking "turn" in Heidegger's thought. Keane argues that the Heideggerian turn, which is usually delineated as the dividing line between Heidegger's early and late periods, should not be understood simply as a shift of position. Rather, the "turn" unfolds as a topical motive in Heidegger's thinking, and this motive explains the transition from the early analytic of Dasein towards the history of being. The turning, however, does not entail a renouncement of transcendental philosophy but its rearticulation.

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